Originally nothing more than a humble fisherman's soup using the remains of the day's catch, bouillabaisse has evolved into one of the great Provençal dishes.

bouillabaisse

SERVES 4 **PREP** 20 MINS **COOK** 45 MINS **FREEZE** NOT SUITABLE

4 tbsp olive oil
1 onion, thinly sliced
2 leeks, thinly sliced
1 small fennel bulb, thinly sliced
2–3 garlic cloves, finely chopped
4 tomatoes, peeled, seeded, and chopped
1 tbsp tomato purée
1 cup dry white wine
1½ quarts (1½ liters) fish or chicken stock
pinch of saffron threads
strip of orange zest
1 bouquet garni
salt and freshly ground black pepper
2 tbsp Pernod
3lb (1.35kg) mixed white and oily fish and shellfish, such as monkfish, red mullet, shrimp, and mussels, heads and bones removed
8 croûtes, to serve

for the rouille
4¼oz (125g) mayonnaise
1 bird's-eye chile, seeded and coarsely chopped
4 garlic cloves, coarsely chopped
1 tbsp tomato purée
½ tsp salt

1 Heat the oil in a large pan over medium heat. Add the onion, leeks, fennel, and garlic and cook, stirring, for 5–8 minutes, or until the vegetables are soft but not colored. Stir in the tomatoes, purée, and wine.

2 Add the stock, saffron, zest, and bouquet garni. Season with salt and pepper, and bring to a boil. Reduce the heat, partially cover, and simmer for 30 minutes, stirring occasionally. Process the rouille ingredients in a blender until smooth. Transfer to a bowl, cover, and chill until required.

3 Just before the liquid finishes simmering, cut the fish into chunks. Remove the zest and bouquet garni and add the firm fish. Reduce the heat to low and simmer for 5 minutes. Add the delicate fish and simmer for 2–3 minutes, or until it is cooked through and flakes easily. Stir in the Pernod and season to taste. To serve, spread the croûtes with rouille and place 2 in the bottom of each bowl. Ladle the soup on top.